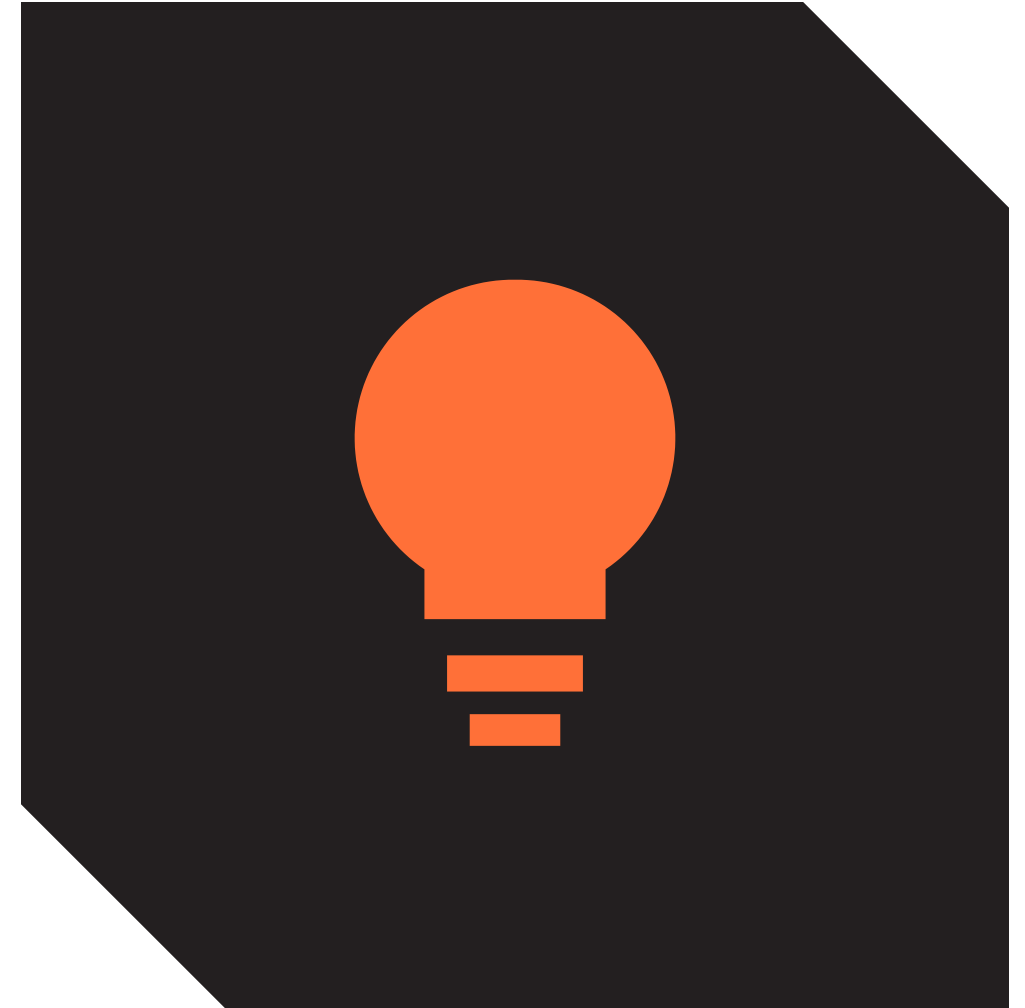


How does AI actually 'think'?

Understanding the technology behind the tools you use





**When you ask ChatGPT
a question, do you think
it 'understands' you the
way a human would?**

Does it understand you?

- Yes — it understands
- No — it predicts
- Somewhere in between
- I genuinely do not know

Predicting is not understanding

What a language model does	What understanding would need
Predicts the next likely word	Grasps what the words mean
Patterns from its training data	Experience of the real world
Always produces an answer	Can say 'I don't know'
Sounds confident when wrong	Knows where its knowledge stops

It predicts the next word — and it is wrong often enough to matter

Did you know?

92%

UK UNIVERSITY STUDENTS
USING AI FOR ACADEMIC
WORK

HEPI Survey 2025

51%

STUDENTS NAMING
HALLUCINATIONS AS A
MAJOR CONCERN

HEPI Survey 2025

45%

SCHOOL STUDENTS WHO
HAVE USED AI

HEPI 2025

So — does it understand you?

A**No — it predicts**

It works out which words are likely to come next, from its training data.

B**It has no experience**

No feelings, no memories, no consciousness to draw on.

C**It can be confidently wrong**

Fluent, coherent and completely incorrect, all at once.

D**But it is still useful**

A powerful tool when you know what it is doing.

Two words worth knowing

Large Language Model (LLM)

AI trained on billions of texts to predict and generate human-like language, by pattern rather than by meaning.

Hallucination

When AI confidently generates false information, because it predicts 'likely' text rather than checking facts.

Being AI-smart

01

Know what it is

A pattern-matching tool, not a thinking being. It doesn't 'know' facts.

02

Verify

Check what matters against reliable sources before you trust or share it.

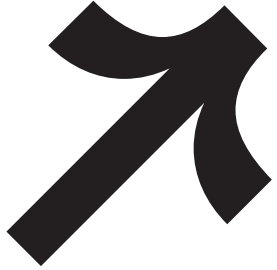
03

Be specific

The more specific your question, the better the output.

Three habits that follow from knowing how it works

Keep humans in the loop



Autocomplete, not an oracle

AI is a powerful tool — but like any tool, it has to be used properly.

If any of this affected you

You will not be in trouble for asking for help.



Reporting and support

Childline — 0800 1111

<https://www.childline.org.uk>

Samaritans — 116 123

<https://www.samaritans.org>

Young Minds — mental health

<https://www.youngminds.org.uk>

CEOP — report abuse or exploitation

<https://www.ceop.police.uk/safety-centre>

Internet Watch Foundation — report an image

<https://report.iwf.org.uk>

UK Safer Internet Centre

<https://saferinternet.org.uk>